Scraps

By Jane Martin

The lights come up on a woman in a multi-colored patch-work costume. Red, blue, green, yellow. Button eyes, yarn hair, pearls for teeth. It is the Patchwork Girl of Oz. She is using a stand-up vacuum cleaner. She turns it off and looks at the audience.

INTRODUCTION

Though rewarding, being a stay-at-home mom isn't easy. In fact, many women are surprised to find it's the hardest job they've ever had. Days spent without a single adult conversation, quieting your child's screams in the store, cleaning bloody knees, carpooling, disciplining, doing laundry, changing diapers, packing lunches, cleaning house and planning meals may leave you wondering, "Is this really worth it?" The "I'm just a mom" syndrome attacks routinely, suggesting the world is moving on without you while you watch Barney with your 3-year-old.

What happens when your children are old enough not to need the constant attention? In Scraps by Jane Martin we find an extreme case of a stay-at-home mom coping with her unnoticed and unappreciated status. She escapes into a fantasy life in which she reinvents herself as a character from Oz (perhaps her childhood link to a daughter who no longer needs her). She describes herself as "something between a rag doll and a rainbow." This reference ties into her obsession with the Land of Oz as her escape. The comic

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overtones of this piece make her common tragedy that much richer. Scraps by Jane Martin.

I spend more and more time in Oz. Since I've turned thirty-five Since Suzanne is in high school. This is Scraps. I had a dressmaker do it. It's not the only one I have. I have Ozma, I have Dorothy, I have Glinda the Good Witch. I'm even beginning to go out in this stuff. The midnight Rocky Horror Show, St. Patrick's Day parades. I went down one night to a gay bar and they waived the cover charge. Always as Scraps. My face doesn't show. Jack doesn't even know I have the books. He sure as hell doesn't know I do this. You know about the Patchwork Girl? It's the seventh Oz book. She was made from a patchwork quilt by Dr. Pipt, the crooked magician, to be his servant. He sprinkled the "powder of life" on her. But what nobody realized is that Ojo had dumped a bunch of *cleverness* into the Patchwork Girl's head. Too much for her to be satisfied as a servant. So she set off for the Emerald City with Ojo and the Transparent Glass Cat with the ruby heart

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and pink brains and the Living Phonograph. They called her Scraps and sometimes Patches.

I wish I was clever. Oh, I know how to hid nail holes with toothpaste, and how to spray cut flowers with hair-fix to make them last longer, but I've never had a job because I don't know how to do anything. I mean anything they pay you for. I'm not too good at learning new things either. I just freeze up or something.

God, I loved the Oz books when I was a kid. Do you know the countries? Well you know the Munchkins. Everybody knows the Munchkins. The Winkies where everything's yellow. Jack Pumpkinhead, the Tin Woodman, The Scarecrow, they all have their castles there. Gilliken Country, Quadling Country. I can get around better in any one of those places than I can in downtown Cleveland. When Jack goes I just sit looking out the window for a long time and then I close the drapes and spend the day in Oz. I can clean and stuff and still be there. Jack doesn't understand why I put yellow linoleum in the kitchen.

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Nobody dies in Oz. No matter what's happening to you Ozma watches on her magic picture and you always get saved. Listen, there are great bad guys! Old Mombi, The Gnome King, The Skeezers. You think I'm ill don't you? You want to send me to group therapy or self-improvement seminars or off to take night classes towards a law degree. God I hated school! How could anybody like it? Hell, you can live a whole life and never have to subtract. Have you noticed that nobody ever talks about anything? I bet I haven't heard anybody talk about anything in two years. God knows Jack doesn't. In the morning he reads me the cereal boxes out loud. He thinks *I'm* boring. He wouldn't think I was so boring if he came home and found me in this. What would he do I wonder? Call his mother for advice. She'd tell him to buy me a Cuisinart and an exercycle.

I live in Oz. I see it all. I've gotten so I can smell it. "Two or three hours walk along this trail brought Ojo and Scraps to a clear level country where there were a few farms and some scattered octagonal houses, all bright Quadling red and smelling of

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peppermint." I can live in that sentence for a full 3 hours. You know what? I like that a lot better than life.

Someday I'll be at the front door when Jack comes home. The Chevette will pull up and he'll have the week's chart, the Southeastern sales figures, the demographics under his arm. And there I'll be to give him a nice kiss, holding the spatula, me, Scraps. "You certainly are a wonder, my dear, and I fancy you'd make a splendid pin cusion. If you belonged to me, I'd wear smoked glasses when I looked at you." (SHE takes the "SCRAPS" head off) But I do belong to you Jack. I'm your helpmeet, your homemaker.

The thing that frightens me is I'm getting flashbacks, just like combat or acid.

We had some people over. Jack had bought an Atari. You know, those television computer space games? Asteroids, Space Invaders, Cosmic Cadet. God, I hate the sound of it. They were talking about municipal bonds or something. We were all around the T.V. with the pretzel mix. Jenny, Allen, Marty, Turk, Jack, me. And I went to Oz. I was in trouble and I was

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being rescued from a whirlpool by this Ork . . . a bird with four wings, four legs and a propeller tail, and I guess Jack was talking to me and I didn't answer. He had to shake me. I really didn't know where I was. I ruined his best score in the Atari. I suppose he'll leave me when he finds out. Take the Irish setter. He's the provider. Jesus, I'll have to make a living, won't I? Maybe Ozma will see me in her Magic Picture. Then they'll send the Scarecrow to come and get me and we'll ride the Sawhorse all the way back to the Emerald City. We'll lunch with the Hungry Tiger and the Cowardly Lion. And the Scarecrow will say, "Why here's a right curous creation, midway between a ragbag and a rainbow. Why my dear, (SHE puts the "SCRAPS" head back on and sings.) you are quite bedazzling!" The scarecrow has the very best brains the Wizard ever made. Perhaps we'll be married.

Kizzle-Kazzle Kore

The Wolf is at the door

There's nothing to eat

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But a bone without meat

And a bill from the grocery store.

(She freezes for a beat and then begins vacuuming.)

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AWARD HISTORY

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